HUMAN BY DESIGN

WHY THE FUTURE OF AI IN EDUCATION MUST BEGIN WITH EMPATHY

Shanti Maluleke, Founder of B.Still Foundation



images/ freepik.com

Can AI make learning more human?

As artificial intelligence reshapes education, one question becomes urgent: Can AI truly make learning more human? The global conversation often focuses on innovation and access: integrating AI into classrooms, expanding digital literacy, and preparing students for a tech-driven future. Yet access alone does not equal equity.

Across the Global South, millions of learners face barriers that technology alone cannot solve: poverty, language, trauma, and mental health challenges. In under-resourced classrooms, where emotional and social needs are often overlooked, AI presents both opportunity and risk. It can either deepen inequality or bridge it.

Beyond access: Emotional intelligence as the new frontier

For nations like South Africa and other BRICS+ countries, AI offers a chance to leapfrog systemic barriers. Where decades of underfunded schools and geographic disparities have limited opportunity, AI can provide personalised, scalable learning that is contextually and culturally relevant. It can empower educators, reach underserved populations, and support mental wellness in ways traditional systems have struggled to achieve.

True accessibility is measured not by login counts but by whether learners feel seen, supported, and capable of thriving. The next frontier in education is not only digital, it is emotional.

Imagine systems that adapt to both academic performance and emotional engagement, detecting fatigue, prompting reflection, or connecting learners to support. Imagine teachers freed from administrative burdens, focusing on relationships that define meaningful learning. When designed with empathy, AI can restore the humanity that mass education systems have too often lost.

Redefining progress for an inclusive future

But emotional intelligence must lead the AI revolution in education. Machines may process information faster, but they cannot replace the nuance of empathy – the teacher's intuition, the peer's encouragement, the human instinct to care. Education is not simply the transfer of knowledge; it is the cultivation of self-awareness, connection, and resilience.

For BRICS+ nations and the wider Global South, this is especially urgent. AI can be a tool for inclusive growth, equipping young people with both digital and emotional literacy skills that will define future workforces, foster social cohesion, and strengthen local innovation ecosystems. South Africa, with its diverse population and complex socio-economic landscape, exemplifies both the challenge and opportunity. AI can empower learners in townships and rural areas, shaping a generation ready to thrive in a digital, interconnected world.

Global leaders shaping AI policies must expand the definition of progress. Innovation cannot be measured only by efficiency, but by empathy, by how technology helps us care, include, and understand one another.

The goal is not to build systems that out-think us, but ones that remind us why we think and feel at all.